

CETEARYL ALCOHOL

_____Name
_____Date

also called... **cetyl stearyl alcohol**, **cetostearyl alcohol**, or **Emulgin L**. It is *not* the same as cetyl alcohol. It does *not* show cross-reaction with cetyl alcohol or sodium cetyl stearyl sulfate.

What is it?

Cetyl stearyl alcohol is a half and half mixture of two forms of alcohol—cetyl (C₁₆) and stearyl (C₁₈). It serves as an emulsifier and stabilizer in many cosmetics, creams, and prescribed skin medicines. The cosmetic grade of this product may also contain up to 5% of myristyl (C₁₄) and lauryl (C₁₂) alcohols.

Where might it be found?

Facial cleanser
Moisturizing cream, lotion
Ointment
Facial moisturizer
Eye cream
Anti-wrinkle cream
Shaving cream
Hand cream
Sunscreen
Hair conditioner
Detangler
Hair spray
Hair color
Hair bleach
Hair remover

Some prescription skin meds
Laundry stain remover

How to avoid it:

To avoid cetearyl alcohol check the complete ingredient list of each product you use for one of the names highlighted above. For products already at home that do not list ingredients, go to the store and inspect the original box or package. Some products' ingredient lists are available on the internet at the manufacturer's website, the store's website, or at websites such as <http://householdproducts.nlm.nih.gov>, <http://www.cosmeticsdatabase.com>, or <http://www.drugstore.com>.

Ask your beautician, hairdresser, masseuse, physician, nurse, and others to avoid using products containing cetearyl alcohol in your care.

To identify possible workplace exposure, check the complete ingredient list of all solutions and products encountered. Wear protective rubber or vinyl gloves if you cannot avoid touching this substance.

Cetearyl alcohol is a mild irritant, especially on damaged skin. It is only rarely an allergen. Your doctor may suggest you do a Repeat Open Application Test (ROAT) with your products that contain this ingredient. The results could guide recommendations.